Twins are birds #4

Why is Generosity Violent?

Why did Cortiez take it all away?

THE PROBLEM

Why did Cortiez take it all away?

Wormwood Scrubs. Car park. White van. A what3words geolocation for the specific co-ordinates of *Lock Stock* era Guy Ritchie London grit. A time and a place to mask up, clamber a chain link fence, offload some gear and spout some public school boy cockney-esque appropriations.

Perfuckt, except this was 2022, and the kids clambering the fences to Youtube-posted cheers were about to miss out on a place in 'Da Great Bolo Exchange'- a now-legendary Cortiez sponsored part gear-drop, part performance-art piece.

The first 100 who beat them to it won the privilege of throwing their £800-£1000, Moncler + Supreme + TNF jackets onto what would become a £16k pile of clothes - and trading them out for a £250 Cortiez equivalent.

But why did Cortiez take those kids best jackets instead of just giving them the Bolo? And why did giving up an £800 jacket for a £250 jacket make the whole exchange feel more valuable and not less?

Why is generosity violent?

"Noble and valiant men have the best life; They have no fear at all. But a coward fears everything: The miser always fears presents"

The Tsimshian once told the story of Little Otter, the shape shifting son of a princess who caught Halibut for his people and made his Grandfather proud. So proud that he gathered all the chieftains together, shared the fish with them and bade them recognise Little Otter - and swear not to kill him if they encountered him whilst out hunting.

Naturally as the way is of such stories, one tribe was absent or forgotten - the very tribe whose chieftain subsequently met Little Otter deep in the marshes, saw the especially large fish he had in his mouth and killed him for it.

Full of grief and remorse - the Grandfather accepts piles of gifts in recompense from the forgotten tribe, but they do nothing to assuage his sorrow.

But why did little Otter have to die?

Twins are birds

“"There is no middle path. There is total trust or total mistrust. One either lays down one's arms or one gives everything."

The most important part of the story of Little Otter is not Little Otter himself, or his Grandfather - it’s the Halibut.

The Halibut was wealth that Little Otter’s Grandfather had received and was obliged to share. His good fortune needed to belong not just to him, but to EVERYONE he knew.

Getting everyone else to eat the Halibut wasn’t just some act of kind benevolence, it was a way of pulling them into a cycle of obligation - they would owe Little Otter & his Grandfather, thereby protecting Little Otter from unbounded acts of violence.

Outside of the obligation, the forgotten tribe and their chieftain were free to do what they like - and they did.

Little Otters story is about the deadly importance of sharing, and the fatal consequences of failing to do so.

Why is generosity violent?

"To refuse to give, to fail to invite, just as to refuse to accept, is tantamount to declaring war; it is to refuse alliance and communion."

The Halibut was a gift with strings attached, because all gifts have strings attached.

Gifts and gifting are where the true power of exchange continues to be held - because unlike money - they come with obligation.

Little Otter's Grandfather didn't just give away the Halibut - he held a feast - a social and ceremonial and religious event, where bonds of kinships and love and lawfulness blur and fold into each other to become something way more than a simple economic transaction.

Weddings, funerals, christenings and wakes are shadows of the same thing. The same need to give and receive and reciprocate, the same need to tie people together with bonds of love and obligation, the same threat of dishonor and violence for those who don't attend.

Twins are birds

""Souls are mixed with things; things with souls. Lives are mingled together, and this is how, among persons and things so intermingled, each emerges from their own sphere and mixes together."

- M. Mauss, 1925

All images from either the Met or the Smithsonian CSSO libraries.

The Cycle of the Gift

Gifts are not mere transactions - they are what the Anthropologist Marcel Mauss would call 'total social facts' or in other words, things that contain within them all of the aspects that bind people together.

Gifting works not just through the act of giving, but through the cost that is borne by the giver and passed to the receiver - done so always with the expectation of a return.

Give, Receive, Reciprocate.

Not a single moment like a cash transaction, but a cycle and a struggle where every step reinforces the bond between giver and receiver as they shift the sense of obligation from one to another.

Sharpening blades of loyalty, a dance of smiles and hugs and one-upmanship that twists the players ever-closer to each other.

THE SOLUTION

Why did Cortiez take it all away?

What Cortiez understands - and what many brands do not - is that the kind of exchange that builds true loyalty requires a cycle of lopsided reciprocity. One party must give more deeply than the other for the cycle to begin.

Cortiez could have just given the Bolo jacket away. But asking for their more valuable jackets in return did something way more powerful - it put the brand into their debt, *Cortiez owed them.*

Each kid who left that car park with a Bolo jacket did so not as a customer who'd been short changed but as a giver to whom Cortiez is bound. The repayment is made in cultural capital. Every time the brand grows in stature - the owners of those jackets grow in stature too. Every time Cortiez makes another drop, their claim to have been there at the beginning only grows.

Cortiez took it all away so those kids could be more than just owners of its jackets - they could be creditors of the brand.

AFTERWORD

Marcel Mauss and the politics of The Gift

This one took me ages, which makes no sense because the Gift itself is both a quick read and super easy to understand. It is full of wide ranging examples - I picked the Little Otter story but there are also tales of the Kula Exchange, The Potlatch, The Maori Hau of the Gift - I'd had them in my head as stories from different books, not just this one.

Also the point Mauss is making is powerful - in some ways he makes gifts feel almost ominous (hence my choice of title) - but he strongly believed that the bond of reciprocity and community that gifting creates was sorely lacking, especially in the Utilitarian inspired economies of the two dominant forces of the time he was writing - Britain and America.

The rise of fascism silenced those worries - Mauss was interned in Vichy France and died in 1950. Utilitarianism triumphed and the political message of the Gift was lost. The transactional society we live in today is poorer for it.

Twins are birds

Thanks for reading

Read some more

The Gift - Marcel Mauss, 1925

The Enigma of the Gift - Maurice Godelier, 1999

Stone Age Economics - Marshall Sahlins, 1972

Debt: The First 5,000 Years - David Graeber, 2011

Read more Twins are birds

https://jimmott-collab.github.io/twins-are-birds/